Office vulnerable to ‘group think’, preventing innovation and dynamism of thought. This was one of the accusations leveled at the British Foreign Office post-1918. The inherent discomfort many in the Foreign Office appeared to have in regard to amending their policies and processes could also prove a hindrance when it came to trying to adapt to the rapidly changing nature of the international scene. Being aware of these internal issues of the Foreign Office goes some way to explaining how foreign policy was formulated within the department.

Understanding the Foreign Office mind is further advocated by the likes of James Joll and Zara Steiner. Joll’s concept of ‘unspoken assumptions’ plays a crucial part in his study of the years leading up to the outbreak of the First World War:

When political leaders are faced with the necessity of taking decisions the outcome for which they cannot foresee, in crises which they do not wholly understand, they fall back on their own instinctive reactions, traditions and modes of behaviour. Each of them has certain beliefs, rules or objectives which are taken for granted.[61]

As Steiner explains further: ‘Historical example is used to buttress predetermined conclusions. Experience is assimilated into an existing framework of inherited ideas’ – a process termed ‘mental maps’.[62] To put it another way, Curzon, Hardinge, Crowe and others would invariably use their knowledge, experience and opinions gained prior to the First World War to help formulate their ideas in the post-war years. The fact that each official within the Foreign Office was of the same cultural, ethnic and class background, and tended to view the world in the same way (the Foreign Office mind), meant that these mental maps were rarely challenged – at least not from within the department. The point is an important one. That men such as Hardinge would rather support Curzon, even though he was often wrong in his assertions, than heed the Indian government, must say something about how the Foreign Office mind functioned.